

The Angevin–Albanian element in the Albanian lexicon

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ABSTRACT

While recent work has shown the Angevin Kingdom of Albania in the 13th and 14th centuries to have had a significant impact on Albania with effects ranging from religious demography and socioeconomic structure to architectural and artistic heritage, the linguistic impact of contact between Old French and Old Albanian has not yet been investigated. The diverse strata of the Albanian lexicon have long been an object of interest, but while impressive surveys have analyzed layers as thin as Gothic, to date no study of Angevin–Albanian contact appears to have ever been published. This paper aims to address this oversight and build a foundation for further investigation. After considering the historical context and examining the few Albanian etyma previously attributed to Angevin borrowings in past works, I argue there are at least thirteen highly plausible borrowings from the *langue d’oïl* in Albanian, consisting of two cases that have been supported in recent scholarship and eleven new cases that I present: *napë*, *parriz*, *pëllas*, *kurt*, *trevë*, *bërsi*, *beronjë*, *punjashë*, *turbë*, *fe*, and *pre*. The motivation for each is given by the diachronic phonology of Albanian, corpus evidence for attestation of relevant forms in Old French and *langue d’oïl* varieties, and historical semantic and sociolinguistic considerations.

Keywords: Albania, linguistics, language contact, Old French, Angevin

1 INTRODUCTION

In the study of Albanian, loanwords have always played an especially significant role, especially for its phonological history. While the figure of 90% cited in one popular introduction to historical linguistics (78) may be a bit exaggerated, it might not be by much: openness to borrowings continues to be considered a “characteristic feature” of Albanian (71). While one may be accustomed to viewing loanwords as something to set aside when reasoning about a language’s diachronic phonology, in Albanian they are in fact a huge boon, and extremely important (89).

Albanian is the only surviving member of its branch of Indo-European, and neither Albanian nor any close relative has any significant attestation before the 15th century (90)¹.

Our understanding of Proto-Albanian rests on three pillars: (1) Albanian dialectology, (2) our understanding of Proto-Indo-European based largely on its earlier and more substantially attested other branches, and (3) the presence of identified layers of loanwords (85). While Gustav Meyer’s famous quotation that Albanian was a “half-Romance mixed language” is certainly exaggerated, the most critical of the latter remains the Latin layer, attributed to the six centuries of Roman domination of the area. It is a very “thick” layer: it consists of at the very least 600 items (89), which is higher than the 572 items identified as inherited Albanian words by Demiraj and Dayan (28). The Latin element of the Albanian lexicon penetrates all parts of the lexicon, including the core vocabulary², as well as derivational affixes (89).

As such, all chronologies of Albanian pivot on the period of intense Latin–Albanian contact, and the date assigned to Proto-Albanian itself is consistently given in relation to the timing of contact with Latin (85; 29; 89; 25). Our understanding of Proto-Albanian phonology is in a large part bootstrapped on observed regularities³ in the treatment of Latin loanwords (25; 85; 89), as is to a lesser but still significant extent our understanding of historical Albanian dialectology (19). The reason for this is self evident: reconstructed Proto-Albanian forms, whether based on Proto-Indo-European or on Albanian dialectology, are *reconstructions*, but the sources of Latin borrowings in Albanian are much more solidly corroborated by the wide attestation and knowledge of Latin and its Romance progeny.

However, a known problem is that in some cases it can be hard to distinguish a Latin borrowing from the Roman period from a later Romance borrowing (6). Given the large role of the supposed outcomes of Latin phoneme sequences in modern Albanian in building our understanding of Albanian diachrony, this is a critical factor that must be checked for. For a basic example, consider Albanian *festë* “feast, party, holiday”. Attributing *festë* to Latin *FĒSTVM* via

¹ Messapic, which is quite plausibly posited to be the attested language closest to Albanian (70; 51), does feature hundreds of inscriptions (22); however, our understanding of Messapic is insufficient to be the basis for any reasoning about Proto-Albanian.

² For example, *pak* “few, little” < Latin *PAVCVS*; *shumë* “many, much” < *SVMMVM*; *vij* “I come” < *VENIO*.

³ In the sense of Neogrammarian exceptionless sound change; for a good discussion of the history and actuality of this approach, see Mazaudon and Lowe (72) and Janda and Joseph (53).

Vulgar Latin *FĒSTA would be seriously problematic for our understanding of the outcomes of Latin /s/ in Albanian, which, before /t/ as well as in most other places, regularly becomes /ʃ/ (Albanian *sh*) (25). However, this is a non-issue if *festë* instead reflects a later borrowing from a Romance language; indeed, it has been attributed to Italian *feſta* (47; 20).

Alas, a much more problematic case would be one where, unlike Latin -st- clusters, whose outcomes as borrowings into Proto-Albanian are well attested, the identification of some words as Latin borrowings into Proto-Albanian rather than later Romance borrowings is pivotal in the interpretation of Albanian diachronic phonology. Such is the case with the attribution of *pre* “prey, booty” and *fe* “faith, religion” as Latin borrowings from antiquity (from PRAEDA and FIDEM respectively), as they are ultimately pivotal supports for De Vaan (25)’s argument that intervocalic /d/ was lost in Latin loanwords into Proto-Albanian, an idiosyncratic development that does not occur for intervocalic /d/ in Proto-Albanian native vocabulary. This bifurcation in the fate of intervocalic /d/ between native etyma and imperial-era Latin borrowings in Proto-Albanian is at odds with the earlier view of Orel (85). De Vaan (25)’s argument here requires that the earliest borrowings from Latin into Proto-Albanian are the ones that show effacement of intervocalic /d/; other Albanian words that reflect Latin intervocalic /d/ as *dh* /ð/, such as *modh* “measure (n.)” < MODVS and *prodhoj* “to produce” < PRODĀRE must be later Latin/Romance loans, even though they show the same treatment of intervocalic /d/ as the native vocabulary.

In light of this, it is important to consider the possibility that *pre* and *fe* could in fact be loans, as discussed at greater length in Section 2.4. While no Romance language Albanian was in contact with would have made /d/ in these positions into /ð/ and Italian likely would have retained them as /d/, Old French *regularly* would see them effaced, and thus a French borrowing could explain *fe* and *pre*. While the modern French forms reflecting PRAEDA and FIDEM are *proie* “booty, prey” and *foi* “faith” respectively, these were originally *preie* and *fei*, and the *ei* > *oi* change largely did not affect the western varieties of Gallo-Romance. As I will argue, it was these western varieties that Albanian was likely exposed to, during the medieval periods of Angevin French influence, which saw its peak during the Angevin *Regnum Albaniae* (64).

Yet, to date, there has been no study comprehensively checking the Albanian lexicon for possible French borrowings before the modern period. This might be surprising: there are quite extensive bodies of research examining the various “layers” of loanword residue in Albanian, some

to a very specific level.⁴ (author?) (Hamp) underscores the role that the diachronic phonologies of these layers play in vital questions concerning Albanian, such as its geographic history and relations within Indo-European; it is thus prudent to leave no layer unaccounted for. In addition to extensive studies of the Latin element (13; 6; 65; 44), we also see specific studies on the past relationship of Albanian to Romanian (59; 99), Aromanian (88), Venetian (101), Italian (47; 63; 20) and its influence specifically on Old Albanian (56). Considerable work has been done in identifying archaic Germanicisms in Albanian, including Gothicisms, with quite extensive works (36; 54), even though – quite unlike the Angevin/Albanian interaction – the entire scenario for the sociohistorical context of this supposed Albanian/Gothic language contact amounts to nothing more than guesswork, as Curtis (18) notes. The Gothic or early Germanic vocabulary of Albanian consists of only a handful of items, which is actually comparable to the number of previously proposed Old French borrowings into Albanian (cf. Section 2.1), yet while there are multiple comprehensive investigations into such posited early Germanic /Albanian contact, what I offer here appears to be the first investigation of such for Old French. As seen in (Section 2.3), in a few cases, Old French itself is the best explanation for how some of these early Germanicisms ended up in Albanian. This is methodologically preferable: unlike the mysterious early Germanic–Albanian contact whose occurrence is in part based on the proposed borrowings *themselves*, Old French–Albanian contact is attributable to a sociolinguistic scenario that can be characterized and dated to a specific period.

With the “layers” from other contact periods already meticulously studied, this paper aims to begin to redress the remaining gap: the *Angevin–Albanian* layer, the linguistic legacy of the House of Anjou’s *Regnum Albaniae*.

1.1 The Angevins in medieval Albania

Lexical borrowing, just like any language contact effect, must be considered in the sociolinguistic context between speakers of the languages in question. For our purposes, the “Angevins” in Albania refers first and foremost to the Capetian House of Anjou, which had lands including

⁴ Aside from Latin and Romance, these pertain to the Slavic element (18; 105; 76; 94; 95) including a study on contact specifically with Serbian (83), studies on the Turkish element (10; 7; 30) including with a local subdialectal approach (5), modern borrowings from German (91), studies on both the Medieval and Modern Greek element (98; 82; 62) and the numerically quite restricted remains of the Ancient Greek element (96; 49; 55).

its original territory in Anjou, Touraine, and Maine, and ruled various other lands including Provence, Hungary, Poland, Achaia (in southern Greece) Sicily, Naples, Taranto, and Albania. In the Albanian context, it also refers to the state apparatus they erected in Albania inasmuch as it existed as a political fact, as well as the vassals and courtiers that hailed from the House of Anjou's "home" domains of Anjou, Touraine, and Maine, as well as some who were recruited from elsewhere in northern France. "Angevin-Albanian" refers here to the state of affairs that emerged from the interface between the incoming Angevin element and local Balkan background.

The Angevin project in Albania was initiated by Charles (I) d'Anjou (in Albanian, Karli i Anzhuit) through a *mélange* of marriage-inheritance and conquest, against the background of the dismemberment and contraction of the Byzantine Empire in the wake of the Fourth Crusade. The *Regnum Albania* (Kingdom of Albania, or *Mbretëria e Arbërisë*), the first attested entity of its name, claimed its *de jure* foundation in 1267, through the inheritance of a dowry, and the approval from the Papacy (64). It seems Charles did claim some sort of continuity with the Principality of Arbanon (*Principata e Arbërit*), a native creation, but this claim has been considered illegitimate and anachronistic by at least some topical scholars (104; 33). It came to be *de facto* five years later through military conquest paired with alliances made with the local nobility and urban elites, and would last in some form until 1368. It seems to be a consensus that, like elsewhere, the objectives of the Angevins were imperialistic in nature, aiming to establish an eastern Mediterranean empire that would hopefully include Constantinople. There is some disagreement about whether Albania's intended role in this empire was merely to be a springboard toward greater conquests, of which it was to become merely the "western extremity" (33) or if, instead, Charles intended to make Albania, where the Via Egnatia met the Adriatic, "the heart of his Byzantine Mediterranean empire" (64, p. 13).

Whatever the initial Angevin aims were, there is no doubt that they were technically a failure. The kingdom's maximal borders, which were also its borders only during the first few years of its existence, stretched from the southern hinterlands of Lezhë in the north to Butrint and Corfu in the south, and from the Adriatic in the west to the Black Drin, Lake Ohrid, and Berat and its hinterland in the east. While its fortunes waxed and waned, its zenith was surely in its earliest years, which it never came close to matching. Much of this land was contested for what was a decade of war between the Angevins and a somewhat rehabilitated Byzantine Empire.

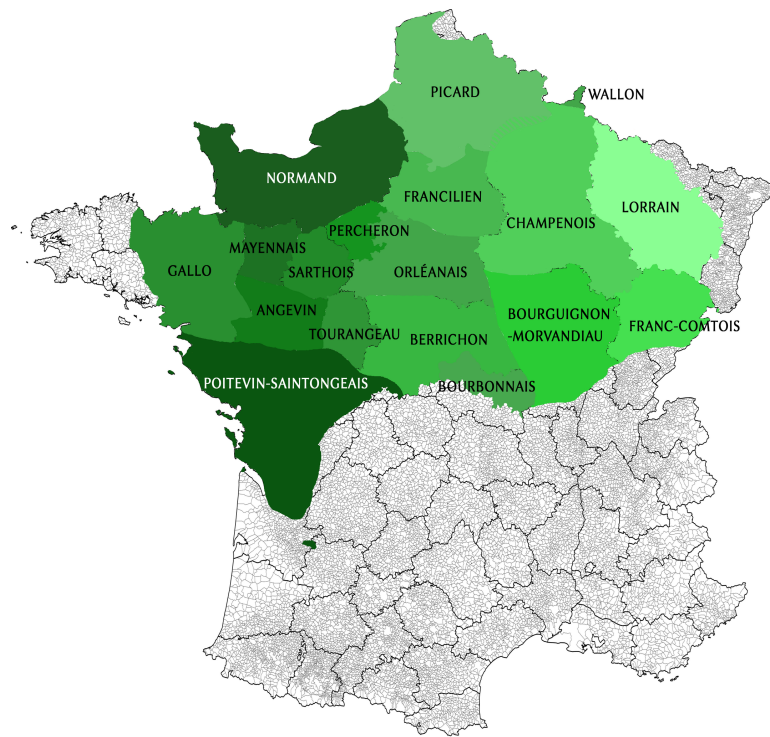


Figure 1. *Langues d'oïl* in France as per Wiktionnaire (User:Lyokoï, 2016, Wikipedia Creative Commons).

Ultimately, the Angevins suffered what became a humiliating loss after a revolt in Sicily, paired with the defection of the local nobility of Albania to the Byzantine side. Although the Angevins were at first welcomed by much of the local elites (38, p. 184-185), being overstretched with their vast domains elsewhere, they repeatedly failed to keep their side of agreements, resorted to tyrannical means of enforcing loyalty, and tolerated a quite tangible degree of corruption (64; 33). For the majority of the existence of the Angevin state in Albania, actual Angevin control was largely limited to cities on the coastal plains, and for much of the “Angevin” period it was even more narrowly limited to Cunavia, the area around Durrës (1), roughly from the cape of Rodon in the north to Kavajë in the south (33, p. 331) as well as the area around Butrint (64, p. 147) and for at some points, it seems, the areas around Vlorë and Kaninë. In 1368, the *Regnum* was brought to an end through its conquest by a rebellious vassal: the Count of Mat, Karl Topia, though a minority view asserts that this actually marked a final phase of its existence, as the no longer Angevin–Albanian but fully Albanianized state *Albaniae* (Lala (64, p. 28), Ippen (52)).

1.1.1 The linguistic milieu of Angevin Albania

The native speech of the House of Anjou's core territory, Anjou itself, was Angevin (100), a member of the dialect continuum called *langue(s) d'oïl*, which is largely functionally equivalent to saying "Old French linguistic varieties". The different *oïl* varieties are divided in various ways, with one scheme displayed in Figure 1. They were already exhibiting distinct traits as soon as we have extensive Old French works, but were probably for the most part mutually intelligible, though differences became more pronounced with time, until the near-total replacement in the last two centuries of all historical non-standard *oïl* varieties by French, which reflects a koine based on the central *Francien* variety. During the era we are interested in (the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries), "Old French", unless otherwise specified, effectively refers to forms that do not substantially differ from those of the *koine* of the period, which was largely based on Francilien, and was slowly gaining ground as the most prestigious variety⁵, with some competition from Picard (73; 21). Francilien is itself a variety of *Francien*, as are Percheron, Berrichon, Orléanais, and Bourbonnais as delimited in Figure 1. Tourangeau may be included in *Francien*, or alternatively in a Western group including Angevin, with which it shares relevant behaviors such as resisting the rounding of *ei* > *oi* (Pope 1934: §1326-7), though only in some contexts. Mayennais and Sarthois, collectively "Mainiot" since both are spoken in the lands of the former County of Maine⁶, although marked separately in Figure 1, are sometimes considered to be varieties of Angevin; for the purposes of this paper, they show the same behavior as Angevin wherever relevant.

The hackneyed question of "what is a language" is largely moot for our purposes; what matters is that the Angevins were functionally diglossic between two identifiable Gallo-Romance idioms: Francien, which we know they used in writing, and Angevin, which they spoke, a situation familiar to those who know the analogous situation of the Normans in England. Indeed, the ascendance of the House of Plantagenet (which also hailed from Anjou) in England precipitated the influence from the Gallo-Romance dialects of their "home" territories in mainland France

⁵ See Pope (1934: §59–69) for a detailed discussion of the dynamics between the different *oïl* varieties during this period.

⁶ Another name is "Manceau", with an altitudinal difference between *Haut-Manceau* (effectively Sarthois) and *Bas-Manceau* (Mayennais).

(21). The Angevin entity in southern Italy and Sicily is of course of high relevance; indeed it did produce a quite tangible interaction between French and the local Italo-Romance varieties (42), with the local Angevins producing Francophone literature *in situ*. Indeed, during the late 13th century, as Williams (103, p. 202) notes in her thesis on Angevin-Italian literature, “French was not just a language spoken or used by those who settled there. It was also the main mode of communication for those who passed through the kingdom as crusaders”. This is, of course, the exact same time at which Angevin Albania was formed, and the language situation of Angevin Albania cannot have been independent of that of Angevin Italy next door. While the role of homeland dialects in Anglo-French is known, identifying such a factor for the Gallo-Romance brought to Italy has been inconclusive thus far. This study is quite relevant to that question, as there *do* seem to be a few specifically Western *oïl* and even specifically *Angevin* reflexes evident in Albanian, which would probably imply the presence of Angevin in Italy as well. For our purposes, we assume both Francien and Angevin were plausibly brought by the Angevins to Albania, drawing from the analogy of not only Norman in England but also the presence of specifically Angevin and Poitevin-Saintongeais elements brought to England by the “Angevin” Plantagenets (21). In theory, the prestige exercised by Picard within the Francophone world is also of note (21; 73), but, despite taking Picard into consideration, I did not find any plausible evidence of any specifically Picard element.

That said, it would probably be excessive to posit that any large share of the Albanian population became bilingual in Old French. Even in areas of direct Angevin control, it does not seem likely that the common people learned French, though the nobility and perhaps part of the mercantile classes probably did. However, one must also keep in mind the prospect of how a loanword can propagate. This was also an era of urbanization, with Durrës in particular growing in population to about 25,000 inhabitants (2, p. 225–226), and Durrës, where the Via Egnatia met the Adriatic, was without a doubt the socioeconomic center of the Albanian-speaking lands.⁷ Thus, even if the Angevins only controlled Durrës and the surrounding area (Cunavia), what they did have was the area that new linguistic material was most likely to spread from, and their pos-

⁷ As pertains to Durrës and the rest of the coastal plains at one point controlled by the Angevins, Ducellier (33, p. 294) argues that, even if unintended, the Angevin period played a decisive role in the homogenization of the area as ethnically Albanian.

session of Butrint and, for a significant minority of the time, the area around Vlorë and Kaninë, was a bonus.

Furthermore, it is worth mentioning that there is a well-established framework where even situations with low levels of bilingualism can result in significant loaning phenomena. Namely, when new cultural concepts are introduced by people speaking a different language, there is a need for words for those concepts, and using the words that already describe them in the contact language, even if it is one you cannot speak fluently, is essentially the path of least resistance. These are quite unlike the “ERIC loans” that one sees around the Balkan sprachbund and elsewhere (57) that arise from persistent bilingualism and human-oriented discourse. What we expect to deal with here are cultural loan(word)s, and also called, in this sense, borrowings of “necessity” (46), in the sense that the concept “necessitates” a name by not already having one.⁸ As it turns out, Albania’s “Angevin period” presents exactly such a situation.

1.1.2 The social relations and sociolinguistics of Angevin Albania?

What is most important about the history here is the social relations between the speakers of *oïl* and the speakers of Old Albanian, which not entirely but almost equivalent to saying the “Angevins” and the Albanians. There seems to be a considerable disparity in the assessment of these relations. As Lala (64, p. 10) notes, the traditional twentieth century scholarship largely saw the *Regnum* as “an Anjou invention ... [with] almost no impact for the Albanians themselves”, except a relationship between imperializing occupiers and exploited natives, with at least some twentieth century Western scholarship explicitly referring to the Angevins’ imperial aspirations as colonialist (33). In Albania, during Communism and beforehand, the Angevins were perhaps most frequently referred to as one of a long list of invaders who tried and failed to conquer the soul of the Albanian.⁹

On the other hand, more recent works have taken a more positive approach, perhaps partly in reaction to the earlier paradigm, viewing the Angevins as contributors to Albania’s heritage (39; 40), with research in artistic and architectural history that focused on a more harmonious

⁸ As opposed to the “unnecessary” loaning for concepts that already have a name; such “unnecessary loans” are the ones that are more characteristic of situations with high levels of bilingualism.

⁹ Statements of the sort are attributed not just to Communist leaders such as Hoxha (37, p. 93) but also men revered as voices of Albania’s late Ottoman national “renaissance” (*rilindja*), such as Kostandin Çekrezi (68).

blending of different cultural motifs in the Angevin-Albanian milieu, such as the adoption of local and Byzantine elements by the rulers and adoption of Western European styles (2, p. 314–315), including Italian humanism, by Albanians, who continued to creatively produce and develop these styles into the fifteenth century (15). Another approach, while acknowledging that the Angevins' aims were fundamentally imperialistic at first at least rather than focused on local development, portrays the local elite as having come to identify with the *Regnum* by their own volition, because they found a way to co-opt it so as to pursue their own interests (64).

There seems to be a fair amount of agreement that the local nobility had a large degree of agency over the course of events (104; 1; 64; 33), even if there may be a disagreement over how much the local elites determined outcomes (61). The initial embrace of the Angevins by the local Albanian, and Greek, is attributed not to the Angevins having played the “Albanian card” (33, p. 294–295), but rather to a local taste for autonomy that had already manifested in earlier in the formation of the Principality of Arbanon (64; 104). If in the 1280s local nobles were turning back to the Byzantines to rid themselves of Angevin excesses, just a decade later their relations with the Angevins would become warm again as allies once their independence became threatened by the expansionist Serbian king Stefan Uroš II Milutin (33, p. 329).

As even the more Angevin-skeptical authors assert, the Angevins did succeed in decisively breaking Albania away from the sociopolitical framework of the Byzantines (33, p. 299–300), with profound effects that reached far beyond the borders of actual Angevin control. In its place, they ushered in Western European feudalism (2, p. 220–224), and the adoption of a new system of public law in the coastal cities on the basis of the Angevin charters of 1272 and 1304 (39). The majority of what was afterward the Albanian nobility was in fact technically ennobled by the Angevins, it seems (40, p. 336–337). Meanwhile, their base in Durrës expanded tangibly as Cunavia urbanized, with people moving to the city from the countryside, a growth in tandem with the expansion of trade routes to and from Durrës (2, p. 225–226). In 1304, Charles II (*Karli i Dytë*), formally integrated the Albanian nobility into the Western inheritance-based feudal structure (64, p. 26); though a closer relationship was not always a warmer one, what matters is that even though the Angevins were geopolitically restricted, their social relations were not necessarily. Each of these aspects both provides a motive to spread French words, and a vector along which they could, and likely would, be introduced to Albanian speakers: indeed,

the adoption of Western titles by the nobility with the adoption of feudalism is in fact old news (34, p. 45). And the initial recipients of such borrowings – the nobility and the population of Durrës, namely – were people with a likelihood to propagate these words: the nobles via the administration of their own territories, and the mercantile city dwellers via the trade routes to and from Durrës.

In addition to the nobility and the city dwellers of Durrës, one must also consider the church as a vector for how French borrowings could propagate. The Angevin–Albanian state also enjoyed a close relationship with the local Catholic hierarchy and, though not without their share of scandals in this area as well (33, p. 296–298), it sponsored the expansion of Catholicism throughout its existence (64). The acceptance of Catholicism by noble families such as the Topia¹⁰ was part of their internalization of identification with the *Regnum*, notes Lala (64); as Egro (34, p. 70) notes, many native Albanian noble families “gave their members to high ranks of the Catholic clergy serving in Albanian lands.” The relations between the Papal curia and the Albanian Angevins were the subject of meticulous study by (64). Building on the already existing foothold in the northern part of the country, the *Regnum* sponsored expansion of Catholicism quite widely it seems, and even if territorially the *Regnum* was only a “phantom” of itself after its disastrous defeat in the 1280s, the expansion of Catholicism or “Catholicisation” actually reached its peak in its last decades (see, in particular (64, p. 145–158)). Of course, such a situation would likely be a means for French borrowings to propagate out of the Angevin-ruled archbishopric of Durrës.

Many of the “Angevin-skeptical” authors might concede that there were multiple vectors for the propagation of contact with what would be the means for linguistic import. And furthermore, it is not absurd that this import would have some lasting impact. Even if the relationship between the Angevins and the local nobility of Albania was fraught when they actually held considerable power, it seems the legacy of Angevin Albania, if not the memory of the actual Angevins, came to be much more esteemed (39; 15), for what it came to represent if nothing else (64). As Ducellier (33, p. 299) states, it gave them “the taste for independence” from the other, non-Angevin, powers in the neighborhood. What the Albanian nobility wanted was perhaps an Angevin Albania without too much of the *Angevins*. Even if, by 1290, the Angevins

¹⁰ Also occasionally spelled a “Thopia”; it appears that “Topia” is now more frequently used in recent works.

were reduced to a “phantom” of their former self, “the nobles tried to personalize this phantom” (64, p. 2). Ironically, the man who destroyed what was left of the *Regnum*, Karl Topia, was apparently named after Charles d’Anjou, whose family’s crest bore the Angevin *fleur de lis*, and who was not shy about his own maternal French heritage (34, p. 47); Lala (64, p. 28) notes that the *Regnum* continued to exist as an idea into even the sixteenth century. If anything, such a prestige likely applied to the lexical artifacts of the former cultural package from the Angevin-Albanian era would be maintained – hence, a long term impact.

2 IDENTIFYING THE ANGEVIN ELEMENT IN ALBANIAN

To identify likely Angevin–Albanian loanwords, both the flaws of an existing etymology and the strength of a possible Angevin–Albanian etymology in its place are considered. The former is judged in terms of the integrity of its claims – if a word is attributed etymologically to an ancient Latin borrowing into Proto-Albanian, it should show consistency with the diachronic cascade of all subsequent regular sound laws that are known (25; 85); if it is an exception, then preferably, in a Neogrammarian fashion, there should be an explanation for the exception in terms of the interference of another regular sound law, or of extra-phonological factors such as analogy, sociolinguistic factors, and so forth. Furthermore, the word should actually be attested in Latin or at least the Romance languages, and preferably Romance languages spoken close to Albania, and within Latin it should preferably have a clear analogy so as to exclude the possibility that the borrowing actually went in the *other* direction, a factor relevant to discussion in the case of *bërsi* (Section 2.2). Aside from looking for potential Angevin borrowings among words thought to be ancient Latin borrowings that fail to show the same regular phenomena as other ancient Latin loans, I also examined the supposed early Germanic lexis of Albania, a set of etymologies that are already considered particularly shaky due to the entirely hypothetical nature of the supposed early Germanic–Albanian contact (18).

In order for an Angevin etymology to be strong, it ideally should be either directly attested in the corpus of historical Old French texts, as accessed through the established French corpora resources. Resources consulted include: the voluminous *Französisches Etymologisches Wörterbuch* (henceforth abbreviated as *FEW* of von Wartburg (102), the *Dictionnaire de Moyen*

Français (DMF) maintained by the public research laboratory group ATILF¹¹, and the *Dictionnaire étymologique de l'ancien français électronique* (DEAFé1). If attributed to a specific dialect, it should be attested in a text attributed to that dialect as reported in the resources mentioned above, or justified based on the known phonological history of Francien or, for reasons described in Section 1.1.1, Angevin or an Angevin-adjacent dialect (87; 100; 32; 66; 21). Additionally, the semantics must be consistent or involve a development that is unsurprising. Etymologies are considered stronger if they pertain to domains that are expected for cultural borrowings (46) given the sociolinguistic context described in Section 1.1.2.

Both conditions must be fulfilled. Although attributing Albanian *drejt* “right, just, correct” (with *drejtësi* “law (practice), justice”) to Angevin *dreit* “right, (as a noun) justice” would in fact work both in terms of historical phonology and semantics, there is no need, because the attribution to an ancient Latin borrowing from *DIRECTVS* “straight” is phonologically plausible, and the same semantic developments are seen elsewhere in Romance. In this case, the burden of (dis)proof is not met. The same can be said if there is an already proposed better source for the loan. For example, it is unnecessary to attribute *borxh* “loan of money” to the *oil* form *borge* “debt”, because Ottoman Turkish *borc* more than suffices, especially considering the much greater time depth of Ottoman rule than Angevin rule. On the other hand, naturally, proposed borrowings attributed to the Angevin presence must be justified in terms of phonology, semantics, and chronology.

2.1 Previous proposals

There are a handful of prior proposals of loans, broadly, from Old French, or from the Angevin period specifically, though there has never been, to the best of my knowledge, a comprehensive investigation before this study. Bonnet (1998: 36-9, 50, 336-7) suggests:

- **shqytar** “squire, valet-at-arms”, formed of *shqyt* “shield” and agentive *-ar* (< Lat. *-ARIVS*), as a direct calque on French *écuyer*, i.e. Old French *escuier*, formed of *escui* “shield” and the cognate agentive suffix *-(i)er*, which Bonnet attributes specifically to the Angevin period. This is, in my view, a smoking gun since it is very convincing, and a signal that at least one Old French *cultural borrowing*¹² specifically during the Angevin period made

¹¹ Analyse et Traitement Informatique de la Langue Française

¹² As defined by (46, p. 46): “a new concept coming from outside”.

it into Old Albanian, just like the same one did into Middle English (where it reflects as *squire*, and also *esquire* and *equerry*). This is also the only item, to the best of my knowledge, specifically attributed by past work to the *Angevin–Albanian* context.

- **kultër** “cushion”, first attested in Bardhi, to either a “medieval” *coltra* or the (source of the) Old French *coltre* > *coutre*; cf also Franco-Italian *coltra* (DEAFél: *coutre*).
- **kortë** “measure of meat”; this one seems less convincing, since “quarter” becoming a metric is probably not a rare development.

Before Bonnet, there were some scattered musings in past work. As we shall see in Section 2.3, this paper also revives the old proposal of Bugge (11) for a French etymology of **beronjë**, which before now has not been followed up. The case of **grill** “lumpy soil, waste land, slate” is possible but inconclusive; attribution to an ancient Latin borrowing from GRACILIS “poor (of soil)” is phonologically difficult; the related but rare **grel** attested in Arbëreshë is indeed likely a “gallicism” borrowed from courtly poetry (74; 6), but it could easily be a doublet; Old French *graisle* “thin, meager” (> modern *grêle*) does not explain *grill* or Arbëreshë *grel*. Lastly, Schuhardt (93, p. 125) attributed **bukël** “weasel” to Middle French *bacoule* “weasel”, but this is unnecessary as the native etymology is perfectly plausible¹³. Thus, in summary, the status quo in the field does already admit the possibility of Angevin loans, yet it limits them to a tiny list of which I find two to be sufficiently strong proposals (*shqytar*, *kultër*); in this work, I propose to add eleven words to this list.

2.2 Angevin cultural borrowings

Albanian **napë** (*f.*, pl. *-a*) is traditionally attributed to Popular Latin NAPPA¹⁴ while a dissenting view attributes it to Italian (20, p. 292). The primary meaning of *napë* is “filter cloth” (6); in effect “napkin, (cloth) towel, kerchief” (84), while other cited (secondary) meanings include tablecloth, cheesecloth, a mourner’s veil or a veil generally, a “light layer or veil on something”,

¹³ *bukël* is generally connected instead with the native root *bukur* “pretty” (84; 74), which matches a fairly widespread phenomenon where the word for “weasel” or “ferret” was replaced by a word meaning “pretty” (French *belle-ette* > *belette*) or, more frequently, “bride”, as seen in Italian, Greek, Turkish, Danish, Bulgarian, Romanian, and so forth.

¹⁴ Per Meyer (74, p. 297), Orel (1998: 282; 2000: 123); Bonnet (6, p. 383).

and a wool neckerchief (20; 80). There is also the related **nap** (*m*), which is Catholic Albanian religious jargon for “altar cloth”. Both etyma have been in Albanian at least since 1702, as they are cited in Da Lecce’s *Dittionario* (20). Latin MAPPA did actually mean “napkin” specifically, while also having a general meaning of “(linen) cloth, sheet”, but, everywhere in Romance except in Gallia and in neighboring Piedmont, the meaning of “napkin” did not leave a trace (*FEW* 2002 6/1, 303b–305a).

While a shared retention of the original Latin meaning by French and Albanian perhaps isn’t alone proof that the Albanian word is actually a French borrowing, it is also dubious that MAPPA/NAPPA even existed in whatever Romance it was that Proto-Albanian was in contact with, since no reflex whatsoever is attested in Balkan Romance, Dalmatian, or in the Romance of Apulia, at least per the *REW* (1935: 388). Thus, in order to defend the view that *napë* reflects a Proto-Albanian borrowing from Latin/early Romance, one has to (a) assume the word survived in “Albanian Romance” despite disappearing (if it ever existed in all neighboring Romance varieties), and (b) the same *m-* to *n-* change must occur. The latter is described as dissimilation, is not without precedent, and is indeed attested (81), but not (as far as I know) anywhere near Albania. Although not an implausible development, it is far from an inevitable one, considering that *m*-initial forms also abound wherever MAPPA reflexes survive, while in Spanish one instead sees *lapa* (*REW* 1935: 388). The *only* Romance varieties where we see an *n*-initial reflexes primarily meaning *napkin* are the *langue d’oc*, Franco-Provençal, and the *langue d’oïl*, excluding Walloon which has an *m*- initial reflex; the Angevin and broader western *oïl* forms are also *nape* with the same meaning (*FEW* 2002 6/1, 301-304) ¹⁵, and both these and Francien have secure attestation with the right meaning from the 12th century onward (DEAFél: *nape*).

This seems to present a much stronger alternative case to a Latin > Proto-Albanian borrowing than the attribution to Italian *nappa*, a rather rare word¹⁶, which means “tassel”, and thus requires some acrobatics to explain how this would have attained the semantics of Albanian *napë*. The same, by the way, would apply to Venetian *napa* which means “fireplace mantel, chimney”. On the other hand, in addition to showing robust semantically and phonologically appropriate attestation before the point of contact, there are yet more reasons why Old French is

¹⁵ Sardinian also has *nappa* which can mean broadly “cloth”, not specifically “napkin”, but this and other reflexes in Sardinian tend to be used instead to mean “spider web” (*FEW* (2002: 6/1, 304a); *REW* (1935: 388)).

¹⁶ Multiple first language Italian informants told me they have never even heard of this word.

a very convincing etymology. Whereas the Italian cognate is semantically remote, over-specific, and sparsely used, the French word long exhibited dynamism, generating various derivatives (DEAFél: nape), and a “courtly etiquette”-type borrowing from a French superstratum into Albanian is quite likely, and has precedent in that the same word and its derivatives were borrowed into Portuguese and English¹⁷ The Albanian Catholic jargon masculine doublet *nap* “altar cloth” also suggests *specifically French origins*: the French Catholic jargon for altar cloth is also *nappe d’autel* (FEW 2002 6/1, 301a).

Another case of a borrowing in religious jargon can be seen in Albanian **parriz** “paradise”, which has long been attributed to Latin PARADĪSVS (77; 16; 84; 44; 65), though with some occasional dissent that has instead looked to Italian *paradiso* (47; 74). One must note that Albanian has a number of synonyms which immediately look like doublets: *parajsë*, *parajs*, and *paradhis* (80). Indeed a local southern Italian Romance variety could be the source of *paradhis*¹⁸, but it could not phonologically predict *parriz*. Although the loss of intervocalic /d/ here is not an issue (16), there are, however, two problems with the Latin etymology. Firstly, Latin /s/ never elsewhere became /z/; it became *sh* /ʃ/ (25, p. 1744) in all positions (85, p. 102-103), and, additionally, the pre-tonic /a/ probably should have reduced to *ë* or been effaced (85, p. 22-23)¹⁹.

These facts rightly cause Bonnet (6, p. 15–17) to raise the alarm that this cannot be a Latin loan, and propose instead Old Venetian *paraíso*, while noting also the Old French *pareis*, and noting also the valuable observation of Meyer that this word is more associated with Catholic Albanian usage, while *parajsë* is instead “Orthodox”; in this view, *parajsë* reflects Greek, as does *paradhis*, “avec une avancée de l’accent sous l’effet d’une influence romane plus récente”. However, why has Bonnet set aside Old French as a possible source, considering that it is both phonologically more plausible, and also the depth of the historical Angevin–Albanian connec-

¹⁷ Cf. Portuguese *guardonapo* < French *garde-nappe*; Middle English *nape* “tablecloth”, *savenape* “tablecloth protector”, *urnape* “overcloth for handwashing”, as well as modern English *nappy*, *napery*, *napkin*, *apron* < Middle English *naperoun* < French *naperon* ‘place mat’.

¹⁸ Helbig (47) attributes this to Calabrian Arbëreshë but it is now identified as broadly Tosk (80).

¹⁹ For just a few examples in the closest possible phonetic environment, consider PARENTEM > *prind* “parent”, PARABOLA > *përrallë* “fable”, PALVMBVS > *pëllumb* “dove, pigeon”. There are exceptions to this rule, but they do not seem to be before *r*, unless the *r* is followed by a nasal consonant, where there are reflexes in /ɛ/, consistent with the Albanian (and Balkan Romance) tendency for pre-nasal raising.

tion to the Catholic hierarchy in Albania (64)? It would seem French indeed makes the best explanation here, and the relevant forms in *pareis* and *parëis* are well attested at the right time in French and Norman at least (FEW 2002 7, 614b); by this point, liaison which would cause the final -s to be /z/ before a vowel was already active in French (87, p. 82–83), so it is easy to imagine Albanians simply interpreted the root word as /pariz/, with a loss of the schwa pretonic schwa. Meanwhile, the known synonym *parajs* (80) seems to be a much more likely reflex than *parriz* if one is going to “blame” Venetian *paraíso*; the same applies to a lesser extent to the possibly feminized form *parajsë*.

Albanian **pëllas** (*m.*) “palace” (Bonnet (6, p. 156,383); Orel (84, p. 318)) is widely attributed to Latin PALĀTIVM *id.* (84; 6; 76; 65; 44), except for Meyer (74)’s attribution to Italian *palazzo*, which has not been supported, probably because it is phonologically difficult. However, there is also a phonological issue with attributing it to an ancient borrowing from Latin PALĀTIVM: we would probably expect the stressed ā to be affected by i-mutation (25, p. 1735) or umlaut (85, p. 24,31), which would predict a reflex of *pëlles* instead. This i-mutation of /a/, which effects both native and Latin vocabulary at the same time (25, p. 1735), is frequently treated as a regular sound change, though it has also been described in less deterministic ways as well (85; 6). If one sets aside /a/ in pre-nasal environments, and before /r/ which is associated with some divergent outcomes for /a/ in both native and Latin vocabulary (85, p. 16-7,31), the patterning of i-mutation starts looking rather consistent: the quite consistent exception is before a palatal place of articulation²⁰; before coronals, i-mutation is overwhelmingly observed. Thus, if *pëllas* is indeed a loan, this would be one less exception to explain, if one wants to establish i-mutation as a regular sound-change.

Angevin *palâs* is indeed directly attested in 1175 (DEAFél: palais2), showing the quintessentially Angevin (100) and Mayennais (32) correspondence of â /a:/ for Early Old French /aj/ in

²⁰ Cf. PACEM > *paq-e* “peace”, FACIĀ > *faqe* “cheek, page, side, surface”; MORTĀLIA > *murtajë* “plague”, PALLIA > *pajë* “dowry, favor”, FALLIVM > *faj* “guilt”; FRAXINVS > *frashër* “ash tree”, FASCIA > *fashqë* “bandage, diaper”, etc.

Of the two exceptions to this exception, *betejë* “battle” may be the irregular doublet of Cham *bëtalë* and Mirditor *bëtajë* (6, p. 133), *vigje* is considered a later borrowing for other reasons (84, p. 507); it is only before *sh* that truly inconsistent behavior manifests: ASPER, OLEASTER, FRAXINVS, FASCIA > *ashpër*, *ullashtë*, *frashër*, *fashqë*, but CASINA, PASTICA, FILIASTER > *qeshër*, *bjeshkë*, *thjeshtë*.

final syllables. This sound change, and the attestation, thus has antiquity deeper than the Angevin presence in Albania, yet it is not broadly “Western *oi*” (87, p. 500-3), but rather specifically an indicator of specifically *Angevin* provenance.²¹ With the probably trivial reduction of an unstressed pretonic *a* to *ĕ* /ə/, and considering the semantics of “palace”, this does indeed suggest itself as another likely borrowing from the language of the Albano-Angevin feudal elite.

Albanian **kurt** “yard, royal court” (84; 80; 6) has been used to make arguments about the outcomes of Latin vowels, in a rather inconsistent manner. Whereas Helbig (47, p. 37) uses it alongside words like *kuq* “red” < COCCUS to claim /u/ as the normal outcome of Latin short *o* in closed syllables via a stage of /ue/ as in Spanish, Orel (85, p.27-28) sees Albanian *o* as the regular outcome of short Latin *o*, and /u/ as the *unexpected* outcome, which he explains by positing “a separate lexical layer, presumably of earlier origin”.²²

A third account might attribute *kurt* instead to Latin COHORTEM (6, p. 132) or CŌRTEM, which are the more archaic forms of the same Latin CORTEM, but the regular outcome of Latin (and Pre-Proto-Albanian) *ō* is *e* (85, p. 32–3), likely via /ø/ (25, p. 1735), with *o* reflexes attributed to a “most recent layer of Latin borrowings” by Orel 2000(:33), as are the few *u* reflexes (84, p. XVII). These few *u* reflexes are shaky.²³ Despite suggesting COHORTEM, Bonnet (6, p. 132) hedges, noting the limited dialectal spread of the word in light of competition with Slavic-borrowed *oborr* and Greek-borrowed *avlli*; he concludes by deciding *kurt* is *also* a Greek loan. But from what? Standard Modern Greek uses no term of the sort, but instead *avlí*, or perhaps *gípedo*, *proávlio* or *anáktoro*. The options are either Byzantine Greek *kourte*, which, as Bonnet admits, actually

²¹ Though this sound change is also marginally found in some neighboring Tourangeau, Norman, and Gallo varieties.

²² His other examples are *furrik* “chicken-coop”, *fushë* “plain”, *kuq* “red”, *rrumbull* “rolled into a ball”, and *shpuzë*. However, *rrumbull* can easily be explained as by Albanian prenasal raising, as can *furrik* (< FORNICEM); curiously, all the remaining examples here are before possible triggers of a palatal-induced raising, as also seen in Balkan Romance.

²³ For example: *ut* “owl” <? *ōtrvs* is actually *hut* in its citation forms in the most authoritative dictionaries of Albanian (80), and either way this smells like onomatopoeia (cf. English *hoot*). The proposed *CĀNŌSVS to explain *kanushë* “stork”, supposedly derived from *cānvs* “white”, has no known Romance outcomes; if we consider instead that this could have been suffixed with the highly productive Albanian derivational suffix *-ushë* (59), this instead looks like an internal innovation based on *kanë* “reed”.

meant “general’s tent”, or Cretan Greek *kourta* “stockyard”. These are not very convincing options – certainly, less convincing than the straightforward French *court* which carries both of the meanings of the word as employed in Albanian, with the original *cort* developing a /u/ by 1100 as seen in *Roland* (DEAFél: cort1).²⁴

Another case where French makes a better explanation than French-via-Greek is that of **trëvë** “land, area, peace”, traditionally attributed to Middle Greek *tréva*, itself from Old French *treve* (84; 16), itself from Old Frankish **treuwa* “long-term armistice” (FEW 2002 17, 361). The Greek word has fallen out of use, and there is really no reason to assume it had to come from a rare and obsolete term in Greek, when it could have much more easily come from a productive (and still productive) term in French, and, better yet, a word whose semantics strongly suggest likelihood of being a loanword as part of the package of cultural borrowings tied to the erection of a Western European style feudal structure in Albania under the Angevin aegis.

Past etymologies for **bërsi** have been many. Because one of its meanings is “must” (fermented fruit juice) and “pomace, marc”, it was at first assumed to reflect Latin *BRĪSA* “grape pomace” (74; 44). However, Latin *BRĪSA* *itself* is considered a borrowing from some Balkan language, via a word cognate to the supposed Thracian source of Ancient Greek *brûtos* “barley beer”, with some blaming a hypothesized Illyrian **brisa* whose cognate is argued to survive in exactly Albanian *bërsi* (97; 92; 9), Pokorny (86, p. 144) arguing the same hypothesized Illyrian passed through Messapic or Venetic to Latin, and Demiraj and Dayan (28) attributing the Latin to Proto-Albanian itself. Meanwhile, Bonnet (6, p. 28) argues the Albanian itself was borrowed from “the same source as the Greek” (which is assumed to be Thracian), while Orel (84, p. 23) argues the same but via a Romance *brūtea*, though this etymon seems unknown to attested Balkan Romance languages. Of course, our knowledge of Thracian is cripplingly limited and our knowledge of Illyrian even moreso to the point of being entirely limited to onomastics (8; 23), so most of this has unfortunately been a lot of fascinating but unfalsifiable conjecture; in any case, there is no agreed upon Proto-Indo-European etymology for this hypothesized Proto-Albanian ancestor of *bërsi* (28).

²⁴ One issue may be the attested Old Albanian spelling in *kurtë*, but this has been explained in morphological terms to more overtly mark the word’s gender, which at that time (unlike now) was still feminine (16, p. 301), as it is in both Latin and French.

However, the semantics of the noun *bërsi* are much broader than Latin *BRĪSA* “grape pomace” or Ancient Greek *brûtos* “barley beer”; AShSh and IGJL (3)’s definition focuses on seeds and grains and doesn’t mention alcohol production; Newmark (80) notes the homophonous verb *bërsi* “to crush, mash”. This hints at its likely true origin: (Western, likely) *oïl* cognates to standard French *brasiller* “to braise”, which developed semantics we can see easily evolving into those of *bërsi*, whereby a mode of cooking came to mean a mode of overcooking to burnt morsels, and from there the aspect of burning was lost, with the semantics reduced to crushing or mashing. The *FEW* (2002: 15/1, 260a) also suggests that the semantic development could be because the same etymon was used to describe a technique for burning wood that left it in small pieces. In any case, at least since Middle French, *brésiller* is attested meaning “to break into small pieces”, with likely candidates being Norman *bresiller* “to crush, pulverise” (in Alençon, *bersiller*), and the *bersiller* “to break into a thousand morsels” (*FEW* 2002 15/1, 258b) of Sarthois (AKA Haut-Manceau).²⁵ In French as well as in Norman and Picard, the past participle of this verb, variously in singular or plural, was detached and lexicalized to refer to various soups or panades made from crushed bits of food while elsewhere it referred to heaps of morsels or twigs (*FEW* 2002 15/1, 258b–259a); no such form is listed by the *FEW* for any Western *oïl* besides Norman, but it is easy to imagine such a past participle in *bersil* (i.e. [bërsi(j)], with the French loss of the final /l/ active already by this point), as the source of *bërsi*. More likely, perhaps, though, is that what was borrowed was in fact the verb *bersiller* as *bërsi(j)*, with the noun *bërsi* derived thereof. To be fair, this does involve some conjecture, but at least the source is attested, and it is not without precedent, given that the same word was borrowed from *oïl* into Dutch (*FEW* 2002 15/1, 260a).²⁶

²⁵ Although no form is cited for Angevin “proper” of Angers i.e. southern Angevin, the other sub-dialect of Mayennais (i.e. Bas-Manceau) has it, as [bërzije]. The word is fairly widely dispersed elsewhere, meaning “to break” in Picard, “to reduce to powder” in Franc-Comtois and Bourguignon (Burgundian), “to crumble, to be prone to crumble” in Saintongeais, “to grind up” in Périgieux, and with the same meaning as Sarthois in *oc* Limousin *FEW* (2002: 15/1, 258b)).

²⁶ And for the likelihood of loaning such words, consider that the English translations for every sense of the noun *bërsi* are loans: *dreg-s* is from Old Norse *dregg*, while *must*, *marc* and *lees* are all from French, while *pomace* is probably from Latin with the Old French suffix *-ace* added.

2.3 Old French as the medium for early Germanicisms in Albanian

As noted earlier, there is a set of words in Albanian that are currently etymologized to “Germanic”, often assumed to represent early borrowings from a Germanic language that have sometimes been seen as relevant for reconstructing the history of the Albanian language and its speakers, with Gothic in particular speculated about (36; 54); despite Goths being present in the Balkans, the exact contact scenario with Albanian, if it ever happened, is entirely hypothetical (18), though the exercise is indeed still worthwhile, as Huld (50) notes. Sometimes, however, a better explanation is a Romance language that absorbed a heavy influx of Germanic vocabulary and has an identifiable historical contact scenario with Albanian. This could easily refer to Venetian, which has a known lexis of borrowings in Albanian (101), but here we discuss those that are best explained with French.

Orel (84, p. 21) asserts **beronjë** “barren woman; English holly; sidwinding adder (venomous snake)” (80) is a borrowing into Proto-Albanian as **bara* from Proto-Germanic **bazaz*, whence English *bare*, Old High German *bar* (id.) and Old Norse *berr* (id.). In this case, not even Gothic can be the source for this supposed borrowing into Proto-Albanian, because Gothic did not undergo rhotacism of **z*. That Proto-Albanian was spoken anywhere close to West Germanic, let alone North Germanic, is not, to my knowledge, argued for by anyone – one must look elsewhere. Of course, this is probably not a single word; as Orel notes, Demiraj and Dayan (28), in my view correctly, derive *beronjë* “sidwinding adder” *separately* from *ber* “bolt, spear”, which has been plausibly identified as a regular inherited reflex of Proto-Indo-European **b^hōrs-* (28).

The word sense of “English holly”, too, may be separate, and derived, perhaps, from *bar* “grass”, from Proto-Albanian **bara*, inherited from Proto-Indo-European (84). However, could the remaining sense of “barren” still be connected to English *barren*, which is from Norman?

Bugge (11) suggested a Romance loan, noting Old French *baraigne* “barren”; Albanian *beronjë* is also noted in passing in that word’s entry in the *FEW* (2002: 1, 243). Angevin, of course, is known to exhibit rounding and backing of the nasal vowel /*ǣ*/, to the point of equating it to nasal o /*ō*/ (100), a trait seen also in Gallo, Poitevin-Saintongeais, and Norman. It must have surely been the case at latest by Later Middle French when the speech of “Normaund, Nautes, Aungers...” gets mocked (87, p. 173), but it is evidenced long before this: for example, what

was *craanter/graanter* elsewhere begins to be seen as *graunt(er)* as early as the twelfth century, albeit mostly in Anglo-Norman²⁷; it is in Anglo-Norman that we attest *baroyne* for *baraigne* in 1270 as well, with the meaning “sterile, unproductive” (DEAFél: *baraing*). This sort of a taboo vocabulary is likely to be borrowed, and one can imagine how it could spread from use within an elite focused on preserving its family line to the populace (as in English), making an Angevin-era borrowing perhaps the most plausible explanation.²⁸

Next is **punjashë** “purse”, which has been held to be a diminutive of an unattested **punjë*, itself supposedly from “East Germanic”, with reference to Gothic *puggs* “purse”, per Meyer (74, p. 357) and Orel (84, p. 350). More likely solutions come from derivations off of the Romance root for “fist”, with special attention to (cognates of standard) French *poignée* “fistful”, which is attested from the 12th century onward (DEAFél: *poignie*, *poigniee*). This alone could easily be the unattested **punjë* from which *punjashë* is said to derive, since Old French /*ʃ*/ originally was /*ũ*/, as could maybe the rarer *poignat* with the same chronology and same meaning (DEAFél: *poignat*), or Old French *poignet* “Pieces of cloth folded transversely and terming sleeve of a shirt, of a robe”, first attested in 1315 (FEW 2002 9, 515). In modern Angevin and some of the other western varieties, the first syllable vowel remains [u], notably.²⁹

Albanian **turbë** “turf, peat (of soil)” (*f.*) is attributed to “Romance” **turba* by Orel (84, p. 469), noting French *tourbe* (with the same meaning) and Italian *torba*, which Orel notes is borrowed from French. There is a problem: no such word ever existed in Latin or Proto-Romance: it is instead attributed in French linguistics to an Old Frankish *turba* (FEW 2002 17, 387b). Not only Italian *torba*, but also Catalan *torba*, Spanish *turba*, and Schwabian/Alsatian/Swiss German *turbe* are all French borrowings, a fact that seems intertwined with the use of turf as a combustible farming material, which is reported first among the Germanic tribes of the North Sea by Pliny (FEW 2002 17, 388a). It must have been spread to France by the Franks, and from France to Italy, Iberia, Switzerland, Swabia, and, it seems, *also Albania*, which is further

²⁷ As early as 1150 in *Lois dites de Guillaume le Conquérant*, in Anglo-Norman (DEAFél: *croire, creanter*).

²⁸ The idiom “*është me barr*” to describe a pregnant woman is probably unrelated, and rather derived from the semantics of *barrë* “load, burden”; that *barrë e shkuar* means “miscarriage” is likely coincidental, but, I admit, could indicate a possible, hitherto uninvestigated, internal derivation of *beronjë*, but that remains to be seen.

²⁹ For *poignée/puinnie* “fistful”: Norman *pougnie*, Angevin and Poitevin-Saintongeais *pougnée* (FEW 2002 9, 517b). For *poignet*: Tourangeau *pougné*, Angevin and Poitevin-Saintongeais *pougné* (FEW 2002 9, 515a).

supported by the fact that Old French securely attests *tourbe* with the right meaning in the early 1200s before Angevin–Albanian contact, and as *torbe* earlier (DEAFél(: torbe2); *FEW* (2002: 17, 387b)).³⁰

2.4 Fe, pre, and the not-so-complicated fate of Latin intervocalic /d/

One quite interesting instance of competing Latin and Romance etymologies is the case of *pre* “prey”, which is attributed to Latin *PRAEDA* “plunder, prey, profit” (84) and is used to buttress arguments about Albanian diachronic phonology (25). While its main reference is in regard to the outcomes of diphthongs (24), it also carries import in terms of the outcomes of /d/, as there is a disagreement on whether the Proto-Albanian (PAIb) outcomes of Latin /d/ match those of Pre-Proto-Albanian (PPAIb) /d/.³¹

While *pre* “prey” is indeed typically cited as the regular outcome of Latin *PRAEDA* after it was integrated into the lexicon (84; 25; 6), the regular outcome may instead be *predhë*, a likely doublet that has long escaped attention and is not considered or mentioned in any of the aforementioned sources which assert *pre* as the reflex of *PRAEDA*. Nevertheless, *predhë* “missile, explosive projectile” is both quite frequently used, and identified in Albanian dictionaries (80; 3), and is productive at least in the military domain (35). What if *predhë* is in fact the regular outcome of *PRAEDA*, while *pre* is instead a later Romance loan? It makes a quite appealing case: hunting and falconry were common pastimes of French nobility, which is no doubt why English *prey* itself is a French (Anglo-Norman) loan, just as are Middle Dutch *prooye* and *prooi* (*FEW* 2002 9, 286b). The borrowing of *pre* (definite form: *preja*) from an *oil* form *preie*.³²

De Vaan (25, p. 1744), argues that native *d became *ð intervocalically, after *r, and before

³⁰ And the *u* in *turbë* points to French rather than Italian *torba*. It seems that this word in Albanian is now increasingly being replaced by *torfë*, which must come be a later Germanic loan, the likely culprit, via Kosovo’s Saxons, being Low German *torf*, which was also borrowed into East Slavic and Walloon; Norman *torve* is likewise a later Norse loan.

³¹ I adopt the framework of De Vaan (25), for whom “Pre-Proto-Albanian” (PPAIb) is the stage before intense Latin contact, and “Proto-Albanian” (PAIb) is the form after the most intense period of Latin contact, but before the split of Gheg and Tosk, and which, in De Vaan (25)’s framework, also predates the influx of Slavic loanwords from circa 600 CE onward.

³² In this case we may not be dealing with a specifically *Angevin* loan, since Angevin (or modern Angevin, at least) has *prâ*; the medieval Angevin form is unknown, but we do observe Old Poitevin and Old Norman *preie* (*FEW*

coda or yod only “after the loss of intervocalic Latin *d*”, which occurred everywhere except after *r*. This disagrees with the view of Orel (85, p. 105), under which Latin *ɖ* became Albanian *dh* (= [ð]) after *r* and intervocalically. These are the exact same positions that native Pre-Proto-Albanian³³ **d* becomes *dh* in the view of Orel (85, p. 65). Essentially, while De Vaan (25) posits a differential treatment of **d* from Latin and Pre-Proto-Albanian sources (whereby the Latin one undergoes an effacement that fails to happen to the native one), Orel (85) sees no reason for them to be treated differently, at least intervocalically. Orel (85) supports his view explicitly with *modh* “bushel” < Latin *MODVS* “measure”, and *prodhoj* “I produce” < *PRŌDĀRE*, whereas De Vaan (25) cites as evidence of effacement *gjq* “trial” < *ĪVDICIVM*, *bekoj* “to bless” < *BENEDICĀRE*, *mjek* “doctor” < *MEDICVS*, and *fe* “faith” < *FIDEM*, while stating that words that violate this such as *adhëroj* “I adore” < *ADORĀRE* are in fact later Romance loans.

However, both Orel (85) and Bonnet (6) have a counter-explanation for the former three cases: the loss of voiced consonants when they began to come into contact with other consonants due to the loss of atonic vowels. As Bonnet (6, p. 166) demonstrates, this is not limited to /d/, but also /b/ and /g/ (*DIABOLVS* > *djall* “devil”; *CABALLVS* > *kalë* “horse”; *CVBITVS* > *kut* “elbow”; *LIBER* > *lirë* “free”; *MAGISTER* > *mjeshtë* “master”). This alone explains almost all the cases that would be used to justify De Vaan (25)’s view that Latin – but not native – intervocalic /d/ was regularly effaced; there appears to be only four cases left: *fe* “faith” < *FIDEM* and *pre* “prey” < *PRAEDA*, as well as *va* “ford” and *nyjë* “knot” which are often attributed to, respectively, Latin *VADVM* and *NŌDVVS*. However, it is also known that *va* could just as easily be inherited from Proto-Indo-European as it could be borrowed from Latin (28; 97). As for *nyjë*, it has been explained as a “singularized plural (originally, *nye*) of *ne*, borrowed from Latin *nōdus*” by Orel (84). One cannot help but notice *nyell* “ankle, gnarl, knot”, which has been explained by Orel as entirely independently coming from Latin *NŌDVLVS* “little knot”. For *nyell*, the loss of /d/ is regularly explained by the same regular effacements of voiced stops brought into contact with consonants by syncope as seen in *mjek* < *MEDICVS*, *djall* < *DIABOLVS*, and so forth. Why must *nyjë*, with its archaic variant *nye* (80), be from an otherwise unattested reflex of *NŌDVVS*, when it could just as

2002 9, 285b), and even in Francien the unrounded *preie* and *praie* (with *ai* becoming /ɛ/) forms continued to be sporadically used in the 13th and 14th centuries (DEAFél: proie), and even as late as 1530 by Palsgrave (*FEW* 2002 9, 285b).

³³ Or, in Orel’s words, Early Proto-Albanian, which for our purposes is functionally equivalent.

easily be a singularization of the known plural of *nyell* < NŌDVLVVS, *nyej*? This possibility cannot be discounted.

This leaves only **fe** “faith” as a case of a Latin /d/ being effaced without any other explanation. But this, too, can be explained once Angevin *fě* is brought into the picture. The shift of Old French *ei* to *oi* in the twelfth century failed to occur in western *oīl*, and indeed this is one of the most salient characteristics of the western *oīl* varieties (87, p. 104–6, 502–3). In Angevin, thus, *fě* corresponds to normative French *foi* “faith”, with similar outcomes elsewhere in the west.³⁴ This opens the possibility that Albanian *fe* “faith” reflects Angevin *fě* and not Latin *fidem*, just like English *faith* reflects Norman *feid*.

Thus, there isn’t a single word in Albanian left whose development needs to be explained by the proposed different treatment of intervocalic /d/ in Latin borrowings into Proto-Albanian, as opposed to native words. This may illustrate that if one is to use a Latin-attributed etymon in Albanian for argumentation about Albanian diachronic phonology, it is essential to make sure it is not instead from a later layer of Romance borrowings, even one as obscure as the Angevin layer.

2.5 Additional tentative suggestions

The following section suggests etyma that may prove to be further borrowings attributable to the Angevin–Albanian interface, but which are not the basis for this paper’s proposal as they are on less certain ground at present.

Thus far, almost all the etyma considered are low frequency words, and many are obscure and specialized. However, one possible case of a high frequency word is **pjesë** “part, piece” (80). Its striking resemblance to French *pièce* was remarked on by Camarda (14, p. 112), but largely set aside (as has Miklosich (77)’s attribution to Italian), in favor of an etymology from Vulgar Latin **pettia* (84; 74; 6; 65; 44), attested in c. 800 as Medieval Latin *PETIA TERRAE* (6, p. 156).

There are two potential issues with this Latin etymology. Firstly, the word is not attested in Eastern Romance (75)³⁵, the word did not exist in Classical Latin, and its source is thought to be a Gaulish *pettia*, from Proto-Celtic **kwezdi-* “piece, portion”, cf. Old Welsh *ped*, Middle

³⁴ Poitevin-Saintongeais has the same outcome as Angevin, while Norman conserves *ei* and Gallo shows a wide range of local outcomes.

³⁵ Romanian *piesă* is a modern borrowing from French.

Welsh *peth* “thing”, Breton *pezh*, and Old Irish *cuir* (69), meaning it may have not been in any Latin that Albanian interacted with. Secondly, whether this is a plausible outcome of a Latin PET(T)IA is unclear. For Orel (84, p. XVI), *pjesë* is one of the cases showing that an earlier layer of Latin loanwords consistently reflect Latin short *e* as *je*, while a later layer is what exhibits a reflex of *i* for Latin short *e*, as in PRESBYTER > *prift* “priest”. The “layers” are themselves based on the elements whose phonologies they are used to justify, which runs the risk of circular logic. Others have sought to explain this difference in terms of an *i*-mutation (25), where the /*ε*/ (i.e. the Late Latin reflex of Latin *e*) was raised to /*i*/ under the influence of /*i*/ or /*j*/ in the next syllable (24), however as De Vaan (25) notes, the conditioning of this phenomenon remains very unclear. For some cases with similar phonetic contexts, it appears that we see full *i*-mutation in the case of MISERIA > *mëshirë* “misery”, but not in MEDICVS > *mjek* “doctor”, while in some other cases it seems there may have been a partial raising, because the /*ε*/ from Classical Latin *e* shows *e*, the regular outcome of “tense” Late Latin /*e*/ (< Classical Latin *ē*), as seen in ALEXIVS > *Llesh* “Alex” and MEDIVS > *mes* “middle, between”. With this in mind, one might have to consider a Romance loan; the Romance sources that could give *pjesë* would be French and Spanish; if this word can be found in Albanian writing before the twentieth century, it may more likely be a medieval French borrowing than a modern one.

The word **ankand** “auction” is cited as a case where Albanian replaced final or intervocalic /*n*/ with /*nd*/ in loanwords, alongside *xhind* “djinn” < Turkish *cin*, *makarunde* “macaroni” < Italian *maccheroni*, and *kondizëm* “icon” < modern Greek *kónisma* (12). However, it should be noted that modern French is the odd one out here, because while the other three could have entered Albanian centuries ago and had enough time to be mutated in this way, modern French borrowings into Albanian are much more temporally restricted to more or less the twentieth century³⁶, and by the time they did arrive, they did so from a prestige language of international communication in a highly literate setting where such mutation would not be expected. This opens the possibility that the source is not modern French *encan* “auction”, but rather Old French *encant*³⁷, perhaps with the post-nasal voicing of /*t*/, though further investigation is necessary to support such an argument, as the date of post-nasal voicing in Albanian remains uncertain (41,

³⁶ Even in 1913 Albania was “as remote as Tibet” for the French, as a contemporary diplomat noted (79)

³⁷ First attested in the 11th glosses of Rashi meaning “public auction” and then in the 14th century in a text from

Hainault (DEAFél: *encant*)

p. 344-345), a question for which *ankand* may be relevant, and also a question which, as (41, p. 541) note, is an areal phenomenon “worthy of more general attention”.³⁸

3 CONCLUSION

Thus concludes my attempt to bridge the gap of a layer of the Albanian lexicon that was hitherto unexplored. This is by no means an exhaustive study, but rather an illustration of how and where to look. Although the Angevin *Regnum Albaniae* fell far short of its goals, and was both geographically and geopolitically quite restricted, its existence was nevertheless accompanied by the sociolinguistic setting conducive to cultural loaning, and furthermore channels, namely administrative, economic, and religious ones, emerged by which these loanwords were likely prone to spread out from the Angevin stronghold of Durrës and Cunavia. Most of the Albanian etyma I propose are largely in the exact semantic domains in which we would expect borrowing in this situation: the religious and the feudal-aristocratic (including the culinary and “table manners” domain, in which concepts often “trickles down” from the elites to the masses); essentially, it resembles the most frequent areas of French borrowings into English in *quality*, even if, given that the Angevins were only in Albania for about a century, the *quantity* is probably not nearly as high as the impact of French upon English. Nevertheless, if I have indeed found fire exactly where the known sociohistorical “smoke” was, there are probably also more loans, more “fire”, to be found by a more thorough look around the vicinity.

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³⁸ Post-nasal voicing affected ancient Latin borrowings (85, p. 114) and also cases like Dalmatian *campuone* > *këmbonë* “bell” (6, p. 19), but the potential role of Slavic borrowings is unclear. The relevant NT clusters were usually lost during the formation of Slavic nasal vowels (Friedman and Joseph (41, p. 345), Collins (17, p. 1459)), but Albanian does appear to Slavic borrowings words where VN corresponds to the Slavic nasal vowel, a fact that may be connected to marginal dialects where this was the regular reflex (85, p. 40) which include dialects in and adjacent to Southeastern Albania (41, p. 319).

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